regular visits and bilateral coordination mechanisms. Additionally, New Delhi began to place a much greater emphasis on connectivity, facilitating the exchange of trade, capital, people, and energy. The smaller South Asian countries began to receive more lines of credit from India's Export–Import Bank, including for major infrastructure and connectivity projects. Border checkpoints and customs were upgraded. Agreements for energy purchases and cross-border electric grids were established. And India became quicker at providing humanitarian assistance following tropical storms, rains, earthquakes, and other natural and manmade disasters. [18]

As part of its Neighbourhood First approach, India also made attempts at recasting regionalism, which had long been held hostage to India–Pakistan differences in the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC). At the 2014 SAARC Summit in Kathmandu, India went ahead with plans for a South Asian satellite involving all other countries after Pakistan blocked consensus. This 'SAARC-minus' approach reflected growing frustrations with Pakistan's intransigence. India also upgraded its profile, funding, and presence in the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC), a long moribund grouping involving South Asian countries minus Pakistan and Afghanistan, but also involving Myanmar and Thailand. [19] In some cases, India opted for smaller mini-lateral solutions, such as a motor vehicle agreement among the BBIN countries (Bhutan, Bangladesh, India and Nepal). After Bhutan expressed objections over the possibility of greater tourist and commercial traffic to their country, this proposal focused on improving overland connectivity between Nepal, India, and Bangladesh.

The Indian government also attempted to extend its neighbourhood—conceptually and practically—to the Indian Ocean. This broader conception incorporated Mauritius and, to a lesser extent, the Seychelles. As with other regional relationships, India increased the frequency of high-level visits and state-backed grants and loans, including for defence articles and infrastructure. It was in a speech in Mauritius that Modi outlined his vision for Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR). [20] India also contributed to patrolling these countries' Exclusive Economic Zones and